



NEXT CARD UP

Three workouts on a loop. Whichever one you did last, you do the next one. There are no weeks in this plan, so there is nothing to fall behind on.

How to use this

THE ONLY INSTRUCTION THAT MATTERS

Open to the card you are doing. Do it. Close the book. Everything else in here is reference you read once on the couch, not something you consult at the gym.

At the gym

Pages 10, 11 and 12. One page per workout. That is it. Print those three and leave the rest at home if you want.

On the couch, once

Pages 4–7 and 14–19. Read them slowly, once. You do not need to remember them — the cards already have the rules built in.

What is in here

PAGES	PART	WHAT IT ANSWERS
1–3	Start here	The one rule the whole plan runs on
4–7	The look	How to build jacked and shredded instead of thick and blocky — and how to keep your traps out of it
8–9	The week	Exactly which workout on which day
10–13	The cards	The three workouts, and the two-exercise version for bad days
14–19	The rules	Adding weight, eating on the drug, and what to measure
20–23	The year	Four phases across twelve months, plus blank log sheets

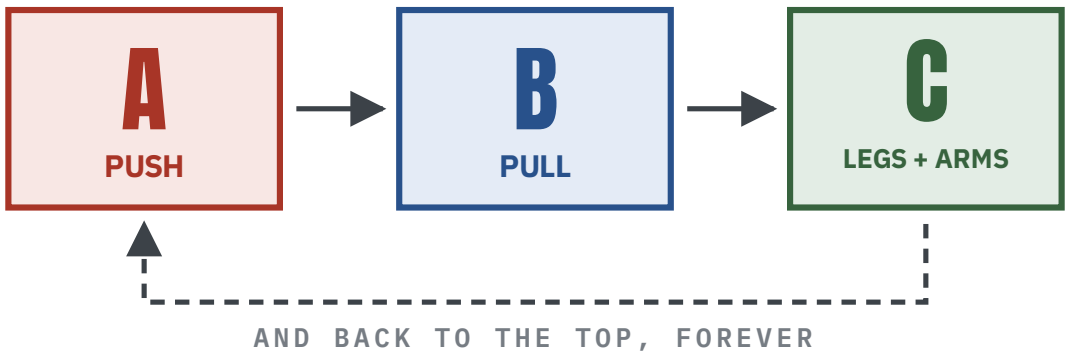
ONE HONEST NOTE BEFORE YOU START

This is training and nutrition guidance, not medical advice. Retatrutide dosing, side effects, bloodwork, and when or whether to come off it belong with the clinician prescribing it — especially if you start dropping weight faster than about 1% of your bodyweight per week, which is the rate where muscle starts going with the fat.

THE ONE RULE

You have not failed at training. You have failed at calendars.

Every plan you quit had a shape you were supposed to fit into. Push Monday, pull Wednesday, legs Friday. Miss Wednesday and the week is ruined, so you skip Friday too, and by day nine you are starting over. **This plan has no shape to fall out of.**



IF YOU MISS A DAY
Nothing happens. The next time you walk in, you do the next card. The deck cannot get out of sync.

IF YOU MISS A MONTH
Same answer. Take 20% off your logged weights for two sessions and carry on. No restart, no penance.

IF YOU ONLY HAVE 12 MINUTES
Do the two shaded exercises on the card and leave. It counts, and the deck advances. See page 13.

WHAT YOU ARE ACTUALLY BUILDING

Jacked and shredded, not thick and blocky.

You said it plainly: you want the lean, defined, wide-shouldered look, and you do not want the built-like-a-fridge look. Good news — those are two genuinely different shapes, and the difference is mostly **where** you add muscle, not how much.

THE LOOK YOU DO NOT WANT

- Upper traps that swallow the neck — the single biggest tell
- A thick, square waist and blocky obliques
- Width that comes from overall mass instead of shoulders
- Everything grown at once, in proportion, including the parts that should stay small

THE LOOK YOU WANT

- Wide side delts — the caps that make shoulders look built
- Wide lats flaring out from a tight waist
- A clean, long line from ear to shoulder
- Visible abs, developed arms, legs that match

THE SHAPE HAS A NAME, AND IT IS A RATIO

It is called the **V-taper**, and it is measured as **shoulder circumference divided by waist circumference**. The look you are describing sits around **1.6**. You move that number two ways, and only two ways: **make the top wider**, or **make the middle smaller**. This plan does both at once and never, ever grows the middle.

Why this matters more than it sounds

A waist looks narrow **by contrast**, not by measurement. Two men with an identical 36-inch waist look completely different if one has an extra two inches across the delts and lats. This is the fastest visible change available to you, it is faster than fat loss, and it is the reason Card A exercise 4 and Card B exercise 1 are the two most important sets in your week.

You already have proof. Your arm-and-shoulder photo reads leaner than your back photos taken at a similar bodyweight. Same body, different silhouette.

THE MAP

What to grow hard, what to leave alone

Not every muscle deserves the same effort. This is the whole trick.

PRIORITY	MUSCLES	WHY
GROW HARD	Side delts, lats, biceps, triceps, chest, quads	Delts and lats build the V directly. Arms and chest fill the frame. Quads balance the whole thing so you do not look top-heavy.
GROW MODERATELY	Rear delts, mid and lower traps, hamstrings, glutes, calves, abs	These are posture and detail muscles. They finish the look without adding bulk anywhere that costs you.
LEAVE ALONE	Upper traps, loaded obliques, neck	These are the three things that turn the shape you want into the shape you do not want. Every one of them is easy to avoid.

AN IMPORTANT DISTINCTION

Upper traps are not the same muscle region as mid and lower traps. The upper traps are the slope from your neck to your shoulder — that is the part that reads as chemically assisted when it gets big. The mid and lower traps sit between your shoulder blades, give you a detailed back and pull your shoulders where they belong. You **want** those, and your rows and pulldowns already train them. Nothing here asks you to avoid back work — only to stop feeding the top slope.

THE EXCLUSION LIST

Not in this plan, on purpose

Every one of these is a good exercise. Every one of them is also a direct upper-trap or waist-thickness builder, which makes them wrong for what you are after.

BUILDS UPPER TRAPS

- **Shrugs**, any variety — the number one offender
- **Upright rows**
- **Heavy deadlifts and rack pulls**
- **Farmer's carries**, heavy holds, power cleans
- **Face pulls** — commonly recommended, but more upper trap than most people realise. Rear-delt flies do the same job for you.

THICKENS THE WAIST

- **Weighted side bends**
- **Loaded twists** with real weight
- Any oblique work that gets progressively heavier instead of staying light and high-rep

Train abs with flexion — crunches and leg raises — at moderate load. Grow the muscle, not the column it sits on.

FOUR CUES

How to keep your traps out of exercises that are not for traps

Avoiding shrugs is the easy half. What actually decides how your neck looks in a year is **technique on the exercises you already do**. Traps are eager and always willing to take over. These four cues stop them.

CUE 1 • LATERAL RAISE • CARD A, EXERCISE 4**Shoulders stay down and away from your ears.**

This is the big one. The moment a lateral raise gets heavy, your traps shrug the weight up and your side delts get nothing. Feel it in your neck? **Too heavy — go lighter, and do not be proud about it.** A 15 lb lateral raise done right builds more shoulder than a 30 lb one done as a shrug.

CUE 2 • ROWS • CARD B, EXERCISE 2**Pull to your belly button, elbows close to your sides.**

Rowing high to the chest with elbows flared turns a lat exercise into a trap exercise. Low and tight keeps it on the lats — the muscle that makes your waist look small.

CUE 3 • OVERHEAD PRESS • CARD A, EXERCISE 3**Stop just short of shrugging at the top.**

The last couple of inches of an overhead press is largely upper trap. Press to nearly straight and stop. You keep the delt and give up almost nothing.

CUE 4 • REAR-DELT FLY • CARD B, EXERCISE 3**Elbows at shoulder height or just below. Never above.**

Let the elbows drift above shoulder height and the movement migrates into traps and rhomboids. Flat, wide and light keeps it on the rear delt.

THE TELL

If your neck and the tops of your shoulders are sore the day after a shoulder or back session, one of these four cues slipped. That soreness is the exact muscle you are trying not to build, telling you it did the work.

DAY BY DAY

Your default week

Four sessions. This is a **default, not a contract** — if you miss Wednesday, you do not skip to Friday's workout, you just do the next card whenever you next walk in. The days are here so you have something to aim at, not something to fail.

Four sessions a week — the target

DAY	WHAT	DETAIL
MONDAY	Gym — next card	~32 minutes. Log your top set on each exercise.
TUESDAY	Walk	8–10k steps. Nothing else. This is a real training day, not a rest day.
WEDNESDAY	Gym — next card	~32 minutes.
THURSDAY	Walk	8–10k steps.
FRIDAY	Gym — next card	~32 minutes.
SATURDAY	Gym — next card	The one that turns a decent plan into a good one. If only three happen, this is the one to drop.
SUNDAY	Weigh-in + tape	Log your 7-day average weight and your waist measurement. Rest. Walk if you feel like it.

BUSY WEEK? THREE IS FINE.

Monday, Wednesday, Friday. Drop Saturday. At three sessions a week each card comes around once every seven days, which holds everything you have and still builds slowly. It is a lower gear, not a failure.

TWO IS THE FLOOR OF THE FLOOR.

Two sessions a week keeps your muscle through a cut. It will not add much. But it is enormously closer to four than zero is, and it keeps the habit alive through a bad month.

WHY THE WALKING DAYS ARE ON THE SCHEDULE

Not to burn calories — the drug is handling that. Walking specifically helps the deep abdominal fat, it helps your focus and mood, and it gives every day a job. Days with no job are the ones that turn into weeks.

THE ROTATION

Four sessions and three cards means your week repeats every three weeks

This is what the loop actually looks like on a calendar. Notice that Monday is a different workout each week — that is correct, and it is the whole point. After three weeks it comes back around.

	MONDAY	WEDNESDAY	FRIDAY	SATURDAY
WEEK 1	A • Push	B • Pull	C • Legs	A • Push
WEEK 2	B • Pull	C • Legs	A • Push	B • Pull
WEEK 3	C • Legs	A • Push	B • Pull	C • Legs
WEEK 4	A • Push	B • Pull	C • Legs	A • Push

Over three weeks that is four sessions of each card — roughly 1.3 times per muscle per week, which is where muscle retention and slow growth live when you are under-fed. At three sessions a week it becomes a clean Monday–Wednesday–Friday A/B/C that repeats every seven days.

If you lose track — and you will

OPTION 1

Look at your log. The last card you wrote a number on is the one you did. Do the next letter.

OPTION 2

Cannot remember and cannot find the log? **Do Card C.** It is the one you are most likely to have skipped.

OPTION 3

Use the web version, which tracks the next card for you and remembers your last numbers.

NEVER DO THIS

Do not double up to catch up. If you miss two sessions, you have not accrued a debt. There is no such thing as being behind in this plan. Two workouts in one day costs you recovery you do not have and buys you nothing.

A

Push

Chest · Shoulders · Triceps

14 SETS

~33 MINUTES

1 Incline dumbbell press **3 × 6–10**

Bench at about 30 degrees. You already do this one, and it is your best chest movement — you never have to touch a barbell again.

2 Machine chest press or pec deck **2 × 10–15**

A machine on purpose: no setup, no stabilising, no decisions. Take the last set close to failure.

3 Seated dumbbell overhead press **3 × 8–12**

The one you already do on the bench. Keep doing it.

CUE 3 » Stop just short of locking out and shrugging at the top.

4 Dumbbell lateral raise **3 × 12–20**

Light, slow, elbows leading the hands. This is a waist-narrowing exercise wearing a shoulder exercise costume — one of the two most important sets in your week.

CUE 1 » Shoulders down, away from your ears. Feel it in your neck? Too heavy.

5 Triceps pushdown or EZ-bar overhead extension **3 × 10–15**

Whichever station is free. Do not wander the gym looking for the other one — they are the same exercise for your purposes.

The floor for Card A: exercises 1 and 2 only — the two shaded rows. Twelve minutes. It counts, and the deck advances.

Rest — 2 minutes after exercise 1 · 90 seconds after 2 and 3 · 45–60 seconds after 4 and 5. Log only your hardest set on each exercise: one number.

Next Card Up

B

Pull

Back • Rear delts • Biceps

13 SETS

~32 MINUTES

1 Lat pulldown 3 × 8–12

Grip a little wider than your shoulders. Drive your elbows down and back, and let your arms fully stretch overhead at the top. This is **the** width exercise — treat it as the most important set of your week.

2 Chest-supported row or seated cable row 3 × 8–12

Chest-supported if the machine exists: no lower-back fatigue, no form decisions to make when you are tired.

CUE 2 » Pull to your belly button, elbows close to your sides. Not high to the chest.

3 Rear-delt fly, machine or dumbbell 2 × 15–20

Light. Rear delts finish the shoulder from behind and quietly improve how you stand. Doing these instead of face pulls is a deliberate choice — see page 6.

CUE 4 » Elbows at shoulder height or just below. Never above.

4 EZ-bar curl 3 × 8–12

Your bicep bar. No swinging — if your hips are moving, the weight was chosen by your ego rather than your biceps.

5 Dumbbell hammer curl, both arms 2 × 10–15

Exactly the way you already do them. Hammers build the brachialis, which sits underneath and pushes the bicep up — it is why some arms look thicker at the same size.

The floor for Card B: pulldown and row only. Two exercises, twelve minutes, still counts — and they happen to be the two that do the most for your silhouette.

Rest — 2 minutes after exercise 1 • 90 seconds after 2 • 45–60 seconds after 3, 4 and 5.

Next Card Up



Legs + Arms

Quads · Hamstrings · Arms · Abs

14 SETS

~32 MINUTES

1 Leg press 3 × 8–15

Feet in the middle of the platform, down to about 90 degrees at the knee. **First three weeks: 2 sets only, stopping 3 reps short.** Being unable to walk on Thursday is the reason you never went back last time.

2 Hamstring curl machine 3 × 10–15

Hamstrings and glutes pull your pelvis back underneath you. A forward-tilted pelvis pushes your stomach out and adds visual inches that are not fat — this exercise is quietly part of your midsection plan.

3 Leg extension 2 × 12–20

Optional if you are wrecked. Skip this before you skip anything above it.

4 Dumbbell curl + triceps pushdown, back to back 3 × 10–15

Curl a set, pushdown a set, no rest in between, three times through. This is your reward for showing up to leg day and it costs six minutes.

5 Cable crunch or lying leg raise 2 × 10–20

Not for fat loss — that is not how fat works. This is so there is something worth looking at when the fat does come off. Keep it to flexion; no heavy twisting.

The floor for Card C: leg press and hamstring curl. Then go home. You still trained legs, which is more than the last several years.

Rest — 2 minutes after exercise 1 · 90 seconds after 2 · 45–60 seconds after 3, 4 and 5.

Next Card Up

THE BAD-DAY PROTOCOL

The floor

This page is the reason this plan will still be running in a year. Every card has **two shaded exercises**. On a day where the full workout is not happening — no time, no sleep, no motivation, brain will not start — you do those two and you leave.

CARD	THE FLOOR VERSION	TIME
A • PUSH	Incline dumbbell press, then machine chest press	~12 min
B • PULL	Lat pulldown, then row	~12 min
C • LEGS	Leg press, then hamstring curl	~12 min

WHY THIS IS NOT CHEATING

The first two exercises of any session carry the large majority of the stimulus. You are fresh, they are the heaviest compound movements on the card, and everything after them is refinement. **A floor session is genuinely most of a workout** — it is not a token gesture, and you should log it like any other session.

The rules of the floor

- ☐ **It counts as a session.** Write it in the log. Advance the deck.
- ☐ **You do not owe the missing exercises to anyone.** They are not carried forward.
- ☐ **Do not decide in advance** that today is a floor day. Go, start exercise 1, and then decide. Most of the time you will finish the card — starting is the hard part, not continuing.
- ☐ **Use it freely.** If a third of your sessions are floor sessions, this plan is still working better than any plan you have quit.

THE TRAP THIS REPLACES

All-or-nothing thinking is the actual mechanism that has ended every previous attempt. Not laziness — **the belief that a partial workout is worthless, which makes zero feel equivalent to seventy percent**. It is not. Seventy percent, done forty times a year, is the whole game.

PROGRESSIVE OVERLOAD

Add reps until the top of the range. Then add weight. That is the entire system.

It is called **double progression**, and it exists so that you never have to make a decision in the gym. Every exercise on every card has a rep range printed next to it. You have one job.

THE RULE, IN FOUR LINES

- Pick a weight you can do for the **bottom** of the range with about two reps left in the tank.
- Every session, try to add **one rep** to your top set. Reps, not weight.
- When you hit the **top** of the range on **every** set, go up in weight next time.
- Your reps will drop when you go up. **That is correct.** Climb back up the range, and repeat forever.

What that looks like in practice

SESSION	WEIGHT	REPS YOU GOT	WHAT YOU DO NEXT TIME
1	45 lb	8, 8, 7	Same weight. Try for 9 on the first set.
2	45 lb	9, 8, 8	Same weight. Keep climbing.
3	45 lb	11, 10, 9	Same weight. Nearly there.
4	45 lb	12, 12, 12	Top of the range on every set » go up to 50 lb.
5	50 lb	8, 8, 7	Right back where you started, with 5 more pounds. Repeat forever.

Five sessions, one exercise, five pounds. Multiply that across three cards and fifty-two weeks and that is what a year of training actually is — not dramatic, just relentless.

HOW HARD IS A SET?

Stop with **1–2 reps left** — the weight is slowing noticeably and you know you could not get three more. Going to absolute failure every set costs recovery you do not have while cutting.

WHAT TO WRITE DOWN

One number per exercise — your hardest set. "50 × 8". That is the whole ritual. If logging feels like homework you will stop, and then you are guessing.

INCREMENTS

How much to go up

The right jump is roughly **2.5–5% of the load**. On small muscles the next dumbbell in the rack is already a far bigger jump than that — which is exactly why the rep ranges on isolation work are wider.

EXERCISE	GO UP BY	REPS DROP	EXPECT A JUMP EVERY
Leg press	+10–20 lb	2–4	1–2 weeks at first
Machine chest press, row, pulldown	+5–10 lb	1–3	3–5 weeks
Incline DB press, DB overhead press	+5 lb per hand	2–4	6–10 weeks
EZ-bar curl	+5 lb on the bar	2–3	4–8 weeks
DB curl, hammer curl	+5 lb per hand	3–5	8–12 weeks
Hamstring curl, leg extension	+5–10 lb	2–4	3–5 weeks
Lateral raise, rear-delt fly	+5 lb per hand	5+	Ride reps to 25 first

THE LATERAL RAISE EXCEPTION

20 lb to 25 lb is a **25% jump** — nothing else in the gym asks that of you. Never jump this one on schedule: ride the reps to 25, *then* take the next dumbbell and start again at 12. If the heavier pair makes your traps take over, put it back. Here, staying light is the strategy.

What a real year looks like

Honest arithmetic, so you stop measuring yourself against a fantasy.

WHEN	WHAT PROGRESS ACTUALLY LOOKS LIKE
WEEKS 1–4	Numbers climb fast on nearly everything — mostly skill with the movement, not new muscle. Enjoy it; do not extrapolate from it.
MONTHS 2–6, CUTTING	Holding your numbers is the progress. Weigh 18 lb less and still press the same dumbbells for the same reps, and you have kept your muscle through a cut. That is the win condition. Write it somewhere.
A GOOD YEAR, EATING ENOUGH	Maybe +10–15 lb per hand on a dumbbell press, +5–10 lb on curls, +60–100 lb on a leg press. Those numbers look small written down and enormous on a body.

THE THING YOU NOTICED

Why you got weaker at the exact moment you started looking better

You cut, you looked better than you had in years, and your lifts fell off a cliff.

That was not you losing muscle. In order of how much it costs you:

- **Glycogen.** Muscle stores carbohydrate, and every gram of it holds about three grams of water. Eat less, store less — and your muscles are literally smaller, flatter and less powerful without a single fibre being lost.
- **Recovery debt.** A deficit slows repair. The session that used to leave you fine now leaves you three-quarters recovered when the next one arrives, and it compounds.
- **Leverage.** You genuinely have less body to press against — one of several reasons to stop worrying about the bench press forever.
- **Sodium — the one almost nobody catches.** On a GLP-1 you are eating very little food, which means very little carbohydrate and very little salt. Low sodium means low blood volume, which means flat pumps, light-headedness when you stand up, and dead sets.

So the fix is not to push harder. Pushing harder into a recovery deficit is how the last several attempts ended.

WHAT TO DO INSTEAD

- **Change the win condition.** While the scale is moving down, the goal is to *keep the same numbers*, not add to them.
- **Put carbs in front of the session.** 30–60 g, 60–90 minutes before. On a GLP-1 your stomach empties slowly, so **drink them** — juice, a shake with a banana, a sports drink. This one change will noticeably bring your sets back.
- **Salt your food, and take 5 g of creatine daily.** Full detail on page 17.

THE BACK-OFF TRIGGER — MEMORISE THIS ONE

If your top set drops **2 or more reps at the same weight, on two sessions in a row, across two or more different exercises** — that is not laziness and it is not a bad week. That is your recovery telling you the deficit is too steep. Eat more carbohydrate, sleep more, or slow the rate of loss. **Do not try to out-discipline it.**

EATING ON A GLP-1

The drug removes your appetite. It does not remove your protein requirement.

The highest-stakes page in the manual. When people lose weight fast without resistance training and without enough protein, a large share of what they lose is lean tissue — commonly a quarter to a third. **The cards solve half of that. Protein is the other half**, and appetite suppression is working against you.

Your daily protein target

0.8–1.0 grams per pound of your **goal** weight — the standard number for holding muscle through a deficit.

GOAL WEIGHT	PROTEIN PER DAY	WHICH IS ROUGHLY	MINIMUM ON A BAD DAY
170 lb	136–170 g	3 × 45–57 g	120 g
180 lb	144–180 g	3 × 48–60 g	130 g
190 lb	152–190 g	3 × 51–63 g	135 g
200 lb	160–200 g	3 × 53–67 g	140 g
210 lb	168–210 g	3 × 56–70 g	150 g

Protein first, at every single meal. Not a health rule — a capacity rule. You have a small number of bites available per day now; spend them on the thing that keeps your arms. On a heavy dose day where 1,200 calories is all you can manage, make 700 of them protein and let the rest fall where it falls.

WHEN NOTHING SOUNDS GOOD

Shakes are legitimate food, not a supplement — two a day is fine. Greek yogurt, cottage cheese, deli turkey, egg whites, rotisserie chicken. **Liquid and cold beat hot and heavy** when your stomach is slow.

RATE OF LOSS

Cap it at **1%** of bodyweight per week; **0.5–0.75%** is the sweet spot. Retatrutide can easily drive faster than that, and faster is exactly where lean mass goes.

CREATINE MONOHYDRATE

5 g daily, any time, no loading phase. Natural, heavily studied, and it does more in a deficit than in a surplus. It also puts 2–4 lb of water *inside* your muscles — a scale increase that means you are winning.

CARDIO

Not needed for the deficit — the drug handles that. Walk **8–10k** steps for visceral fat, mood and focus. Do not add hard cardio that eats the recovery your lifting needs.

MEASURING

Your five-pound daily swing is noise, and it is making you crazy

Sodium, carbohydrate, stress, sleep, and whether you have been to the bathroom. A five-pound day-to-day range is completely normal and contains **almost no information about fat**. Reading it daily is like judging the climate from this afternoon.

Weigh every morning. Never look at a single number.

Same time, after the bathroom, before food. Then look **only at the 7-day rolling average**, compared against last week's average. Any scale app or a spreadsheet column does this for you. One week of average-versus-average is a real data point. One morning is not.

Take a tape measure to your navel once a week.

Same morning, standing, normal exhale, no sucking in. **Waist circumference is a far better instrument than bodyweight** — it moves when fat moves and ignores water almost entirely. Measure your shoulders at the widest point too: that ratio is the V-taper from page 4, and watching it climb beats watching a scale fall.

On looking better dehydrated.

You are right, and you should not chase it. Water under the skin blurs definition, so pulling it out sharpens you for an evening. It is also **not a change in your body**, it costs you strength, and being chronically under-hydrated wrecks the exact sessions that are supposed to build the muscle underneath. Judge the mirror on a normal, well-fed, well-watered day. That is the body you have.

TRACK THIS	HOW OFTEN	WHAT COUNTS AS PROGRESS
7-day average bodyweight	Weekly	Down 0.5–1% of bodyweight per week, no faster
Waist at the navel	Weekly	Any downward drift at all
Shoulders at the widest	Monthly	Holding or climbing while the waist falls
Top set on each exercise	Every session	Matched or beaten while cutting
Photos, same spot and light	Every 4 weeks	The only honest mirror you have
Sessions completed	Rolling	3–4 per 7 days, floor sessions included

Next Card Up

THE HONEST PART

About the stomach

There is no exercise that removes fat from where you do the exercise.

Crunches do not burn stomach fat. If they did, chewing gum would be a jaw treatment. Abdominal work builds abdominal muscle, which is worth doing — but it is not a fat-loss tool, and every year spent hoping otherwise is a year lost.

Your order of operations is genetic, and you do not get to choose it.

You described both parents as carrying weight centrally. That is your map: your body clears the face, then the arms, then the legs and chest — and it defends the abdomen until near the end. **When you were lean enough to see arm definition, your stomach was always going to still be there.** That is not evidence that anything failed. You are running the same fat loss as everyone else on a different map.

What is working in your favour right now.

The class of drug you are on is unusually effective on **visceral fat** — the deep abdominal fat that sits behind the muscle wall and pushes it forward from the inside. That fat often comes off ahead of the layer you can pinch, which means **the shape of your midsection can improve before the pinch test does.** Watch the tape, not your fingers.

THE THREE LEVERS, FASTEST FIRST

- **Lats and side delts — contrast.** Card B exercise 1, Card A exercise 4. The fastest visible change available to you, and it works before you lose another pound.
- **Posture — hamstrings and glutes.** Card C exercise 2. A forward-tilted pelvis adds visual inches to a stomach that is not actually that big.
- **Continued fat loss — slowest, but it finishes the job.** From where you are, abs are likely another **15–25 lb**. The last ten will take as long as the first thirty. That is normal, and it is not a signal to change plans.

AND THE THING YOU SHOULD STOP DOING

Stop judging the plan by your stomach. It is the slowest-responding part of your body and it will be the last thing to change — so using it as your progress meter guarantees that everything feels like it is failing while it is actually working. Judge by the tape, the log and the shoulder-to-waist ratio. The stomach is a lagging indicator, and it will catch up last, on its own schedule.

TWELVE MONTHS

The cards never change. What changes is what you are asking them to do.

Four phases. The exercises are identical in all of them — only the eating and the expectations move. Phase lengths are approximate; move on when the description of the next phase fits you better than the one you are in.

PHASE 1 • MONTHS 1–3

Hold everything. Lose fat.

- **Eating:** deficit, driven by the drug. Protein at target every day.
- **Win condition:** your numbers *stay the same* while your weight drops. Do not chase PRs.
- **Volume:** exactly as written. Legs at 2 sets for the first three weeks.
- **Expect:** 1–1.5 lb per week down, waist down 2–4 inches, lifts flat or slightly up.

PHASE 2 • MONTHS 4–6

Keep cutting. Start building the V.

- **Eating:** same. Watch the back-off trigger on page 16 closely now.
- **Change:** add **one set** to lat pulldown and **one set** to lateral raise. Nothing else.
- **Why:** the movements are automatic now, and these two drive the silhouette.
- **Expect:** loss slowing, abs starting to hint. **This is where people quit.** Do not.

PHASE 3 • MONTHS 7–9

Maintenance. The hardest phase, and the most important.

- **Eating:** at or near goal weight, bring calories up to maintenance for 8–12 weeks. Protein stays high.
- **Do not immediately bulk.** This phase teaches you to hold a body, which is the skill you have never had.
- **Expect your lifts to jump.** Glycogen refills, recovery returns. Real strength gains arrive here.
- **Expect the scale up 4–8 lb in two weeks.** That is water and glycogen, not fat. **Waist is the referee** — if it holds, you are fine.

PHASE 4 • MONTHS 10–12

Lean gain. Actually add muscle.

- **Eating:** small surplus, +200–300 calories a day. Target 0.25–0.5 lb of gain per week, no more.
- **Change:** add a 4th set to Card A exercise 1 and Card B exercise 1.
- **The governor is the tape.** If your waist grows more than half an inch, cut the surplus immediately.
- **Expect:** visibly bigger delts, lats and arms. This is the phase that produces the look.

THEN YEAR TWO

Repeat the loop — but you will cut from a higher muscle baseline, which means you will look dramatically better at the same bodyweight than you do now. **That compounding is the entire long game**, and it is only available to people who are still training in month thirteen.

BACKING OFF, COMING BACK, COMING OFF

The three moments that decide whether this lasts a year

1 • DELOADING, EVERY 6-8 WEEKS

Same cards. Same weights. Half the sets. One week.

Do not take the week off entirely — for you, stopping is the risk, not fatigue. Keep the habit, drop the load. And in an aggressive deficit your recovery is worse than normal, so if you feel like you need a light week at week five, take it at week five. Nothing here is a schedule.

2 • COMING BACK AFTER A GAP

Take a percentage off, do two sessions, and you are back.

TIME OFF	TAKE OFF YOUR LOGGED WEIGHTS	FOR HOW LONG
Under 1 week	Nothing	Carry straight on
1-3 weeks	10%	One session, then resume
1-3 months	20%	Two sessions, then resume
Longer	30%	Two weeks, then resume

Muscle comes back far faster than it was built the first time. There is no restart and there is no penance — you pick up the deck at the next card.

3 • IF AND WHEN YOU COME OFF THE DRUG

This is the moment the whole year is insurance against.

Weight regain after stopping a GLP-1 is common and well documented — appetite returns, and it often returns to a body that has less muscle than it started with. **You are building the two things that protect you:** the muscle itself, which raises what you burn at rest, and the maintenance skill you learn in Phase 3, which is the ability to hold a bodyweight without a drug doing it for you.

Whatever happens with the medication, **the deck does not change.** Same three cards, same rule. **Timing, tapering and whether to stop at all is a conversation with the clinician prescribing it** — not something to freelance, and worth planning well before you get there.

PHOTOCOPY THIS PAGE • ONE SHEET IS ABOUT FOUR WEEKS

Log sheet

One number per exercise — your hardest set only, written as weight × reps. Circle the card letter. If it was a floor session, write "F" in the notes and leave the empty columns empty. **An unlogged session is a guess next time.**

DATE	CARD	EXERCISE 1	EXERCISE 2	EXERCISE 3	EXERCISE 4	EXERCISE 5	NOTES

WEEKLY, ON SUNDAY

7-day
average
weight

Waist

MONTHLY

Shoulders

Photos
taken

STICK THIS ON THE FRIDGE • PHOTOGRAPH IT FOR YOUR PHONE

If you only keep one page

Do the next card. Miss a day, nothing happens. Only 12 minutes? Do the first two exercises and leave — it counts.

A • PUSH

- **Incline DB press** 3×6–10
- **Machine chest press** 2×10–15
- DB overhead press 3×8–12
- Lateral raise 3×12–20
- Triceps pushdown 3×10–15

B • PULL

- **Lat pulldown** 3×8–12
- **Row** 3×8–12
- Rear-delt fly 2×15–20
- EZ-bar curl 3×8–12
- Hammer curl 2×10–15

C • LEGS + ARMS

- **Leg press** 3×8–15
- **Hamstring curl** 3×10–15
- Leg extension 2×12–20
- Curl + pushdown 3×10–15
- Cable crunch 2×10–20

Bold = the floor. Top of the rep range on every set? Go up next time.

Keep your traps out of it

- **Lateral raise:** shoulders down, away from ears. Neck burning = too heavy.
- **Rows:** pull to the belly button, elbows tucked.
- **Overhead press:** stop short of shrugging at the top.
- **Rear-delt fly:** elbows at or below shoulder height.
- **Never:** shrugs, upright rows, heavy deadlifts, farmer's carries, weighted side bends.

Every day, no thinking

- **Protein** — 0.8–1.0 g per lb of goal weight. Protein first at every meal.
- **Creatine** — 5 g.
- **Salt your food.**
- **30–60 g of liquid carbs** 60–90 min before training.
- **8–10k steps** on non-gym days.

The back-off trigger

Top set down **2+ reps at the same weight, two sessions in a row, on two or more exercises** » that is recovery, not effort. More carbs, more sleep, or slow the weight loss. Do not push through it.

What to measure — and what to ignore

Measure: 7-day average weight, waist at the navel weekly, one logged number per exercise, photos monthly.

Ignore: today's scale number, how you look dehydrated, and your stomach — it is a lagging indicator and it will change last, on its own schedule.